

 Red Level: Go Deeper

Name: _____ Date: _____ Period: _____

Dramaturgical Frame: The actor and scholar Anna Deavere Smith (whose work is directly in the Harlem Renaissance oral tradition) says: "Identity is found in the act of becoming another." When you step into a historical character with full commitment — their fears, their hopes, their specific historical context — you gain a form of knowledge that reading alone cannot provide. This is the unique power of theater.

STEP 1: CHARACTER DEVELOPMENT

Build Your Character with Historical Precision

Choose a character: historical figure, fictional voice, or a scene for two voices:

Character name and role: _____**Specific historical moment (year, location, what is happening in the world that week):****Status:** What power does this character have — and what power are they denied? How does that show in their body?**Subtext:** What does this character want to say but cannot — or will not? Why?

STEP 2: WRITE YOUR PERFORMANCE (90–120 SECONDS)

Mark in the script: one moment of STATUS shift (character gains or loses power), one moment of SUBTEXT (what is said vs what is meant), and one SPECIFIC HISTORICAL DETAIL woven naturally into the speech.

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A dramaturgical note explains the research and choices behind a performance. Write yours (5–7 sentences): what historical sources did you draw on? What choices did you make about status, subtext, and voice — and why? What does your performance argue about this character or this moment in history?

CRITICAL REFLECTION

Anna Deavere Smith says "identity is found in the act of becoming another." What did you discover about the Harlem Renaissance — or about yourself — through performing this character that you could not have found through reading?

What are the limits of this kind of historical performance? What risks does it carry?

 Mini Museum Deep Dive

The Harlem in Words section includes actual language from Harlem Renaissance texts. Use three words or phrases from the exhibition in your performance — not as quotation, but woven naturally into your character's speech. After performing, reflect: how did using authentic language change the quality of the performance?

minimuseumproject.com/exhibitions/harlem-renaissance

Research Extension: Find and read one scene from a Zora Neale Hurston play (*Color Struck*, 1926, is freely available online). Analyse: how does Hurston use dialect, rhythm, and silence? How do those choices serve her characters?